

# THE FREEDOM STRUGGLE

The Indian freedom movement picked up momentum after the 1919 Rowlatt Acts, followed by the massacre at Jallianwala Bagh in Amritsar, Punjab. With Gandhi's call for Satyagraha, or peaceful resistance, people from different religions and backgrounds came together to protest. The Non-cooperation (1920–22) and Civil Disobedience (1930) movements saw great success. With the Quit India movement (1942), there was a demand for the immediate withdrawal of the British from the country, followed by India's Independence in August 1947.

## **Ticketless travel**

One of the easiest ways to cause disruption was to encourage ticketless travel and this was recorded in the Non-cooperation and later, the Civil Disobedience movements. Gandhi disapproved of this tactic, but it did not stop people. There were multiple incidents of crowds boarding trains without tickets and entering whichever compartment they chose. "The ultimate goal was to wrest control of India's railways from the state and return it to the people who paid for its operation and to whom it belonged," American historian David Campion wrote. The Railway Board took stringent action to control the mobs by giving their personnel authority to evict people who were not passengers or who did not possess tickets.

## **A tool for resistance**

A key feat of the railways lay in its ability to bring the country together. This was, as Indian historian Tara Chand put it, an "important stage in the evolution and development of national consciousness". It was almost inevitable that it would also play an equally important role in the freedom movement.

The rail system helped in the dissemination of information, and the stations, wrote Indian historian Ritika Prasad, "became vital spaces for anti-imperial mass agitations". For this was where people could gather in massive numbers to catch a glimpse of their beloved leaders. Despite his earlier denunciation of the railways, Gandhi learned to use the trains as a method of reaching out to the people.

Trains also served as an ideal propaganda machine. Everyone, from Congress leaders to the revolutionaries, used them to travel and connect